

SILENT VALLEY MOVEMENT

# WHEN SILENCE BECAME A ROAR

**Environmentalists, poets and journalists generated mass opinion against a hydroelectric project and saved Kerala's Silent Valley, one of India's last remaining tropical rainforests**

BY JUMANA SHAH

A thick, velveteen canopy that shuts out the sun in layers of foliage, creepers, ferns and lichen making up the thick undergrowth that carpets the ground beneath, the Silent Valley is a natural wonder—an 89 sq. km tropical rainforest at the heart of the Nilgiri biosphere reserve in the Western Ghats in Kerala's Palakkad district and a repository of hundreds of rare varieties of flora and fauna. Long before the destruction of the Amazon rainforest became a global cause celebre, environmental activists, poets, journalists and concerned citizens united to save this ecological hotspot from the jaws of 'development'.

In the early 1970s, the Kerala State Electricity Board (KSEB) proposed a hydroelectric dam across the Kunthipuzha river that ran through the forests. The dam would have submerged 8.3 sq. km of the core forest area. The proposal, when mulishly insisted upon by the state, was decried by activists, scientists and biologists. The decade-long Silent Valley Movement, spearheaded by the progressive scientific and cultural organisation Kerala Sasthra Sahitya Parishad (KSSP), thus gathered momentum.